

STUDENT HANDOUT

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Making Something New

Grades 3–4

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Context: The Harlem Renaissance (c. 1920–1935) was a golden age of Black art, music, literature, and thought centered in Harlem, New York. Artists like Langston Hughes, Duke Ellington, Zora Neale Hurston, and Aaron Douglas weren't just creating beauty — they were arguing, through art, that Black life was worthy of celebration and respect.

ACTIVITY 1 · PLANNING FRAME

Your Harlem voice

Imagine you are a young artist in Harlem in 1925. Before you write, plan:

I am (name, creative form): _____

What I create: _____

What I want the world to understand: _____

One word that describes my style: _____

ACTIVITY 2 · WRITE IN FIRST PERSON

A voice from Harlem, 1925

Write a poem, the opening of a story, or a monologue in the voice of your Harlem artist. Write in first person (I / me / my). Use vivid, specific detail — what do you see, hear, feel on the streets of Harlem?

OPTIONAL: SKETCH YOUR ARTIST, YOUR CREATION, OR A SCENE FROM HARLEM

ACTIVITY 3 · WHAT DOES YOUR CREATION ARGUE?

Art as a statement

The Harlem Renaissance artists weren't just making beautiful things — they were making an argument. What does your imagined creation say about Black life in 1925?

ACTIVITY 4

Then and now

Think about a modern musician, artist, or writer whose work makes a statement about identity or justice. How is what they do similar to what the Harlem Renaissance artists were doing?

Modern artist I'm thinking of: _____

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

The Harlem in Words poetry workshop in the exhibition uses the same word categories that Harlem poets drew from: Dreams, Nature, Music, Emotion, Action, and Harlem. Build a poem and compare it to your writing here.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Read your poem or monologue aloud at home. Ask: *"Can you tell what argument I'm making — what I'm saying about who I am and what matters?"*